

JUNYI YANG

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Neighborhood care access. Whether the street structure around a care facility makes it part of daily life or an isolated destination, and for whom.

Proximity is not access. Nearness predicts use poorly, especially for older adults living alone or without a car.

Street-network analysis. Space syntax, betweenness centrality, and local integration, used to measure access rather than distance.

Overlapping exposure. How heat, aging, and disability meet in the same neighborhoods rather than acting separately.

Design research. Testing these questions through mapping and drawing, not statistics alone.

EDUCATION

Washington University in St. Louis

Master of Urban Design, Aug 2024

Master of Architecture, May 2023

City University of Wuhan, Wuhan, China

Bachelor of Engineering in Architecture, Jun 2021

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Washington University in St. Louis | Research Assistant

Delmar Traffic Calming, under Prof. Catalina Freixas, Fall 2024

- Contributed to the redesign of five intersections in St. Louis, MO; produced Photoshop collages illustrating future phases and supported community engagement sessions

SMOOTH House, under Dr. Hongxi Yin, Fall 2022

- Produced plan drawings, sections, and construction detail drawings; developed renderings for client review

Independent course project | Radical Mapping course

St. Louis Heat Vulnerability GIS Mapping, under Prof. Patty Heyda, 2024

- Layered heat-island intensity, social vulnerability index data, healthcare access, tree canopy, and transit coverage in a GIS analysis of St. Louis

Xiangyang Urban Planning and Design Research Institute | Planning & Design Intern

Xiangyang City Aging Care Facility Planning, Jul 2018 – Aug 2018

- Conducted demographic field research and needs assessment across Xiangyang districts to inform a citywide senior-care strategy.
- Assisted in developing a three-tier planning hierarchy (community, district, city) for allocating elder-care facilities relative to population density and existing service networks.

PUBLICATIONS & PRESS

- Yang, J. *Proximity is not access: New York and Shanghai*. Abstract accepted, Urban Transitions Conference, 2026.
- *Plug In The Canal and Making Places of Joy*. Washington University in St Louis presents ten architecture student projects. Dezeen, Sep 2024.
- Yang, J. *Transformable Architecture: An Alternative for Human Communication in a Post-Pandemic World*. Applied and Computational Engineering Conference (ACE), Xi'an, China, July 2023. <https://doi.org/10.54254/2755-2721/25/20230733>

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Washington University in St. Louis | Teaching Assistant

ARCH438 Environmental Systems, Critic: Prof. Catalina Freixas, Spring 2023, Spring 2024

- Assisted with syllabus revisions and course preparation; taught Grasshopper, Rhino, and Photoshop; delivered lectures; reviewed and graded student work

ARCH538 Advanced Building Systems, Critic: Prof. Chandler Ahrens, Fall 2023

- Supervised students through coursework completion; provided design critique on technical and conceptual development

PROFESSIONAL PRACTICE EXPERIENCE

SMBW, Richmond, VA

Nov 2025 – Present

Architectural Designer

- Ronald McDonald House Charities (RMHC), a 59,095-sf residential facility providing free lodging for families of hospitalized children, with guest floors designed to accommodate occasional patient stays and a shared courtyard serving as open space for the surrounding neighborhood, Richmond, VA
- Tree Hill, a 2,770-unit / 1,160-ksf master-planned development; contributed to the Phase 1 Design Guidebook (481 units) covering the urban plan, street and road design, and building-type standards for single-family, townhouse, condominium, and multi-family typologies, Richmond, VA

Christner Architects, St. Louis, MO*Nov 2024 – Aug 2025**Architectural Associate*

- University of Missouri Children's Hospital, 3rd Floor Surgery Buildout, a 26,068-sf surgery expansion (MRI, OR, PACU, P/R suites), Columbia, MO
- Missouri Baptist Medical Center, Linear Accelerator Addition, a 2,066-sf interior expansion and 4,651-sf exterior courtyard redesign integrating new construction with an existing facility
- St. Louis Community College, Wildwood Campus Expansion, a 135,000-sf combined Health Sciences and Technology Studies building

Hellmuth + Bicknese Architects, St. Louis, MO*May 2023 – Nov 2024**Design Intern*

- Saint Louis Zoo, Education Center Design, a 12,022-sf institutional renovation incorporating sustainable design strategies
- Pagedale Community Development (Beyond Housing), Amphitheatre & Children's Park, two pocket parks including a 23,137-sf amphitheater and a 15,250-sf children's park

HONORS & AWARDS

- Outstanding Award, National Green Building Design Skills Competition, China Green Building Council, Jun 2020
- 3rd Prize, Annual Excellence in Design Award, Hubei General Institute of Planning and Design, Dec 2019
- 1st Prize, "Customizable Unit Design" Competition, City University of Wuhan, Jun 2017
- Honor Scholarship, City University of Wuhan, 2017–2021

SKILLS & LANGUAGES

- Methods: spatial network analysis, field survey and needs assessment, comparative case study
- GIS & spatial analysis: ArcGIS
- Design & visualization: Rhino, Revit, SketchUp, AutoCAD, Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign, rendering (Lumion, Enscape, D5)
- Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native); English (professional proficiency)